HDR DATASET NOTE

MRC streptomycin trial for pulmonary tuberculosis

HDR-GB-0001 | version 1.0.0 | 2026-11-11

DOI	Pending, minted at publication
CREATORS	Imad El Badisy
COVERAGE	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
PERIOD	1947 to 1948
UNIT	Patient
LICENCE	CC BY 4.0
LANDING PAGE	https://elbadisyimad.com/hdr/datasets/gb-streptomycin-tuberculosis-trial/

Description

The Medical Research Council trial of streptomycin plus bed rest versus bed rest alone in 107 young adults with acute progressive pulmonary tuberculosis, published in 1948 and widely seen as the first modern randomised controlled trial. Patient-level records reconstructed from the published report.

A small, famous trial that is ideal for teaching randomisation, two-arm comparisons and ordinal outcomes.

GOOD FOR

- Teaching the analysis of a randomised trial
- Ordinal and binary outcomes

NOT GOOD FOR

- Evidence on current tuberculosis treatment

Origin

ORGANISATION	Medical Research Council, Streptomycin in Tuberculosis Trials Committee
PUBLICATION	*Streptomycin in Tuberculosis Trials Committee (1948). Streptomycin treatment of pulmonary tuberculosis. British Medical Journal 2(4582): 769-782*
COUNTRY	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
ADDRESS	https://CRAN.R-project.org/package=medicaldata
ACCESSED	2026-11-11
REUSE TERMS	Records reconstructed from the published 1948 report and distributed openly in the medicaldata R package (MIT).
HOW OBTAINED	Taken from the BioBench R package (dataset streptb), which took them from medicaldata::strep_tb.

Files

File	Content	Rows	Cols	Size
`streptomycin_tb.csv`	One row per patient	107	13	12 kB
`gb-streptomycin-tuberculosis-trial.xlsx`	All tables in one workbook, with About and Variables sheets			17 kB

SHA-256 checksums of every file are listed in `manifest.csv` on the landing page.

Variables

`streptomycin_tb.csv` One row per patient

Variable	Type	Description
patient_id	string	Invented patient identifier
arm	string	Treatment arm (Streptomycin, Control)
dose_strep_g	number	Daily dose of streptomycin (g)
dose_PAS_g	number	Daily dose of para-aminosalicylic acid (g); 0 for everyone in this trial
gender	string	Sex (M, F)
baseline_condition	string	General condition at baseline (1_Good, 2_Fair, 3_Poor)
baseline_temp	string	Maximum evening temperature at baseline, in four bands (degrees F)
baseline_esr	string	Erythrocyte sedimentation rate at baseline, in four bands (mm per hour)
baseline_cavitation	string	Cavitation on the baseline chest X-ray (yes, no)
strep_resistance	string	Streptomycin resistance at 6 months (1_sens_0-8 sensitive, 2_mod_8-99 moderate, 3_resist_100+ resistant)
radiologic_6m	string	Radiological response on chest X-ray at 6 months, from 1_Death to 6_Considerable_improvement
rad_num	number	Radiological response at 6 months as a number (1 death to 6 considerable improvement)
improved	boolean	Improved at 6 months (TRUE if rad_num is 5 or 6)

Known issues

Read these before analysis.

1. **Demonstration entry.** Taken from the BioBench R package to show how HDR presents a dataset. It has not gone through HDR review and will be removed before launch.
2. **Reconstructed, not original, records.** Rows were rebuilt from the tables of the 1948 article, so the joint distribution of variables may differ from the true data.
3. **strep_resistance and radiologic_6m are measured at 6 months,** after treatment, and are not baseline predictors.
4. **No one received PAS** in this trial (dose_PAS_g is always 0).

How to cite

Imad El Badisy (2026). MRC streptomycin trial for pulmonary tuberculosis (version 1.0.0) [Data set]. HDR: Health Data for Research. https://elbadisyimad.com/hdr/datasets/gb-streptomycin-tuberculosis-trial/

Please also cite the origin: Medical Research Council, Streptomycin in Tuberculosis Trials Committee, Streptomycin in Tuberculosis Trials Committee (1948). Streptomycin treatment of pulmonary tuberculosis. British Medical Journal 2(4582): 769-782.

Versions

Version	Date	Changes
1.0.0	2026-11-11	Demonstration release

This note was generated by HDR from the deposit metadata on 2026-11-11. HDR datasets reproduce their origin as faithfully as possible; they are not official statistics. When a value matters for a decision, check it against the origin named above.